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FIELD GUIDE 06

Business Travel Nutrition Plan

Airports, hotel buffets, client dinners and 6am flights. How to come back from a four-day trip the same weight you left.

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Travel doesn't break your diet. Improvisation does.

Nobody gains fat on a business trip because hotel food is uniquely fattening. They gain it because every single food decision is made hungry, tired, and on the spot.

The fix isn't willpower, it's **pre-deciding**. Ninety percent of what follows happens before you reach the airport. Once you're travelling, you execute a plan instead of negotiating with yourself in a Kolkata hotel lobby at 11pm.

The travel objective — lower the bar deliberately

Trips under 4 days

Maintain. Hit protein, keep steps up, don't chase fat loss. Coming back at the same weight is a win.

Trips over a week

Run the normal plan. Long trips are a lifestyle, not an exception. Find the gym, find the routine.

The packing list

Item	Why
Whey protein in ziplock portions (4–6)	Solves breakfast on every 6am flight day
Collapsible shaker	Weights nothing, removes every "no protein available" excuse
Roasted chana / makhana packs	The airport-lounge snack replacement
Resistance band	Turns any hotel room into a gym
Refillable water bottle	Travel dehydration is routinely mistaken for hunger
A few protein bars	Emergency only — for the 4-hour delay with nothing open

ONE RULE TO REMEMBER

Never board hungry. Every bad travel eating decision traces back to arriving at the airport with an empty stomach and 45 minutes to kill.

The playbook by situation

The airport

- **Order:** eggs in any form, grilled chicken sandwich (eat the filling, half the bread), curd, chaas, black coffee, idli with sambar
- **Avoid:** the lounge buffet grazing loop, samosa-and-chai combos, fruit juice, "healthy" muffins
- **Lounge tactic:** make one plate, sit facing away from the counter, and don't go back. The unlimited-food setting is designed to defeat you.

On the flight

- Skip the pre-packed sandwich unless you're genuinely hungry. It's usually 400 calories of nothing.
- Drink 500 ml of water per two hours in the air.
- No alcohol on flights under four hours. It stacks dehydration on top of dehydration.

The hotel breakfast buffet

This is your single best meal of the trip and most people waste it on toast, juice and parathas. It's the one place with unlimited free protein.

Take	Leave
Omelette (order 3 eggs, veg-loaded)	Packaged fruit juice
Boiled eggs — take 2 extra for later	Croissants, pastries, white toast stack
Curd / yoghurt	Sweetened flavoured yoghurt
Idli + sambar, or 1 paratha (not three)	Cereal with the "healthy" label
Fresh fruit, black coffee	Puri bhaji, fried items

The client dinner

The hardest meal, because refusing food is socially costly in Indian business culture. You don't refuse — you sequence.

- Eat a 25 g protein snack at 6pm. You arrive able to make choices.
- Order a protein-led main and let the shared starters be the shared starters.
- **Drinks:** whisky/gin with soda, or a beer. Sip slowly. Two is the number.
- Accept the dessert plate. Take two bites. Nobody counts, and refusing outright draws more attention than eating a little.

Movement, and the return

The 15-minute hotel room workout

On a travel day, do this. It's not optimal training — it's a placeholder that keeps the habit alive.

Exercise	Sets × Reps
Bodyweight squat (3 sec down)	3 × 20
Push-up (feet on bed for harder)	3 × 12–15
Band row	3 × 15
Reverse lunge	3 × 10 per leg
Plank	3 × 45 sec

Steps beat the gym on travel days

You will not always find the hotel gym open at 6am. You can always walk. Airport terminals, the walk to the client office instead of the cab, a 20-minute loop after dinner. Aim for the same 8,000 — it protects more than the workout does.

THE RE-ENTRY RULE

The trip doesn't do the damage. The four days after it do — "I've already fallen off, I'll restart Monday." **Your next meal after landing is a normal meal on the plan.** Not a reset, not a punishment. Just the next meal.

Pre-trip checklist

- ☐ Protein portions and shaker packed
- ☐ Resistance band in the laptop bag
- ☐ Snacks packed — chana, makhana, one bar
- ☐ Hotel checked for gym / walkable area
- ☐ Decided the travel objective: maintain or run the plan
- ☐ First meal after landing already planned

What a good trip looks like

Same weight on return. Two or three sessions done in some form. No day where you ate nothing until 4pm and then everything until midnight. That's it. Travel is about not going backwards.